rameters—'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'.

Moreover, to provide a more relevant and accurate picture, MDRA evaluated colleges based on current year data. The ranking tables also give parameter-wise scores to provide deeper insights on key aspects of decision-making by various stakeholders. Since last year, the survey has also come out with the first ever ranking of colleges in major subjects such as Economics, History, English, Psychology, Sociology, Political Science, Physics, Chemistry, Botany, Zoology, Hindi and Sanskrit based on the objective data submitted by the colleges.

The ranking was done in multiple steps.

- An extensive desk review of MDRA's database was conducted to prepare a list of colleges in each stream. Only those colleges which offered full time, in-classroom courses and had at least three pass-out batches till 2023, were considered. In 12 streams, undergraduate courses were ranked. In Mass Communication and Social Work, post-graduate courses were evaluated.
- Experts with rich experience in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters for different streams. Indicators critical for establishing best colleges were determined and their relative weights finalised. For fair comparison on year-on-year basis, weightages of parameters stayed unchanged from last year.
- Comprehensive objective questionnaires were designed for each of the 14 streams taking into account these performance indicators and were put up in the public domain—on the websites of INDIA TODAY and MDRA. The MDRA directly contacted about 10,000 colleges fulfilling the eligibility criteria seeking objective data for verification. Attested hard copies and soft copies were sought—1,779 colleges submitted institutional data along with voluminous supporting documents.
- After receipt of the objective data, MDRA verified the information. In case of insufficient/incorrect data, respective colleges were asked to provide complete, correct and updated information.
- Perceptual survey about these colleges was carried out among 1,859 well-informed respondents (559 senior faculty members, 328 recruiters/professionals, 383 career accelerators and 589 final year students) across 27 cities, divided into four zones.

North: Delhi, Noida, Ghaziabad, Gurgaon, Faridabad, Lucknow, Kota, Amritsar, Chandigarh, Ludhiana and Roorkee

East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati, Patna and Raipur

West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad, Indore, Panaji and Nagpur

South: Chennai, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Kochi and Coimbatore

- National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective field of experience and were given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightages respectively. The respondents also rated the institutes on a 10-point rating scale on all five key parameters.
- While computing objective scores, it was ensured that aggregate data alone is not used; data was normalised on the basis of number of students for fair comparison. The total scores arrived at from the objective and perception surveys were added in the ratio of 60:40 for 11 professional courses while a ratio of 50:50 was taken for academic courses—arts, science and commerce—to get the final combined score.
- The MDRA core team was led by Abhishek Agrawal (executive director), comprised of Abnish Jha (project director), Vaibhav Gupta (research manager), Aditya Srivastava (research executive) Abhay Pratap Singh Rawat (assistant research executive) and Manveer Singh (senior executive EDP). ■

STREAM	NO. OF PARTICIPATING COLLEGES IN...						
	2024	2023	2022	2021	2020	2019	2018
ARTS	186	173	172	162	131	121	102
SCIENCE	211	198	187	179	145	130	108
COMMERCE	229	225	213	202	167	151	121
MEDICAL	55	57	53	55	50	50	39
DENTAL	62	61	60	59	47	47	46
ENGINEERING	284	278	269	249	248	242	220
ARCHITECTURE	45	40	42	44	31	31	25
LAW	70	72	62	67	49	47	47
MASS COMMUNICATION	56	56	47	49	40	39	25
HOTEL MANAGEMENT	76	76	71	69	60	51	39
BBA	213	201	184	179	147	132	85
BCA	169	171	149	146	113	97	75
FASHION DESIGN	59	51	49	47	35	33	28
SOCIAL WORK	64	56	56	52	39	36	28
TOTAL	1,779	1,715	1,614	1,559	1,302	1,207	988